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Nyoro marriage and affinity

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I now consider the relationship from *mwihwa's* side. He may take and eat or drink anything eatable or drinkable which he finds in his *nyinarum's* house, and nothing he takes may be grudged to him. He may borrow tobacco, a bicycle, even clothes, without asking. If *nyinarum's* wife refuses to cook a meal for him when asked he may kick and stamp on the three hearthstones where she cooks (*kusamba ha ihiga*). If he does so food will never cook over that fire again; *buro* (millet porridge) will spill out of the pot before it is cooked, and *nyinarumi* and his wife will go hungry. In this way, Banyoro say, *mwihwa* can completely break up his uncle's household, for if the latter's wife never gives her husband a good meal he may drive her away and claim the return of the *mukaga* he paid for her. Care is always taken that *mwihwa* should not sit on or near a hearthstone, lest these unhappy consequences be brought about by accident.

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It was noted above that *mwihwa* is entitled to the head of any goat or ox killed for a feast in *nyinarum's* home, also that he can claim a cash payment when one of his 'mothers' (i.e. female agnates of his mother) is being married. In *nyinarum's* house *mwihwa* is a privileged person. I was told that if he found *nyinarumi* beating his wife he could order him to desist, threatening if he did not do so never to come to his house again. This would portend grave misfortune for the household. Like the ghost of a domestic slave *mwihwa's* ghost is much feared, and so is his curse. It is said that the ghost of an offended *mwihwa* may finish off a whole lineage.

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But although *mwihwa* has many privileges in *nyinarumi's* house, he also has obligations there, and he is subject to certain specific ritual prohibitions. When *nyinarumi* is having a feast, *mwihwa* should collect firewood and make a fire outside for the guests to cook at. He should also light the first fire in a new house. It is said that formerly *amwihwa* would be expected to help the group of his *banyinarumi* if the latter were involved in war or feud, and that he would even be expected to go in front of the war party where he would be most likely to be killed. This obligation was not of course reciprocal; it could hardly be, for a man has only one group of *banyinarumi*, but he may have many widely scattered 'sisters' sons'.¹ There are certain things, also, which may not be done in *nyinarumi's* home. *Mwihwa* may not (unless he wants to injure the family) squat on or kick the cooking-stones. He may not sit on the stone on which meal is ground; if he does *nyinarumi's* teeth may fall out. He may not 'climb on to *nyinarumi's* bed' or sleep with his wife (though he may joke familiarly with her). He should not even go into the room in which his *nyinarumi* sleeps; one informant told me that though he had lived in his *nyinarumi's* house for years he had never once been in his bedroom. None the less some men admit that they have slept with the wives of their *banyinarumi*, 'to protect them from the rats' (*kulinda mbeba*), they claim in extenuation. If a man found his sister's son *in flagrante* he would have to make a hole in the wall of the house and the culprit would have to leave through it:² 21 he could never return to that house again. There is some doubt as to whether a man could ever inherit his *nyinarumi's* wife, and I have never heard of such a case; it could in any case only happen if there were no possible heirs among the deceased's agnates. 'A *mwihwa* can only inherit when the *ruganda* is finished.' *Mwihwa* may not climb on the roof of *nyinarumi's* house. He should not walk through *nyinarumi's* growing crops. In particular, he should not take hold of anything which is new in *nyinarumi's* house. Thus he may not lay hands on a new cow, goat, or bicycle, and he may not touch or even approach the bride of any of his *banyinarumi*. I have been told of one other usage, now perhaps obsolete. After a death, it is said, the children of the dead person used to pay a surreptitious visit to the house of a distant *nyinarumi* 'where they are not known' and, without being detected, 'get rid of the death' (*rufu*) there. They did this by leaving in the ashes of the hearth a small piece of plaited grass, previously prepared. This is said to have been a risky undertaking, for if the householders were to discover what had happened they would be very angry.

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¹ This point has recently been stressed by E. H. Winter (*Bwamba*, Cambridge, 1956, p. 187), to whose stimulating treatment of the mother's brother-sister's son relationship among the Amba I am also indebted.

² This is also done in cases where other grave ritual offences have been committed and a condition of serious ritual danger created, for example if a man defecates in the house of another.

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